

It's a neat metaphor and a perfect platform to paint an emerging post-colonial India in the background; from Nehruvian socialism to the Emergency to nascent Hindutva politics. Ms Chitol herself is sui generis; the daughter of a railwayman, a teenage runaway, a college dropout, a young working woman. "I didn't have any anxiety at the start about writing a female character. I was just following my instincts," says Bhattacharya. "But as I went deeper I had to familiarise myself with experiences that are not natural to me as a man. I did a lot more committed reading around various things...to give myself the confidence to undertake female articulation."

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Creating the very specific world of the railways—including union politics, station codes and byzantine employee regulations—also meant considerable research. He spent a decade poring through circulars, government documents and maps, undertaking travel and chatting with ex-employees. "One thing is trying to be on top of the material, the other hard part is to then let that material evaporate off this block of information into something that permeates the world of the novel, so that the granular detail becomes part of the text rather than something that sits on top of it."

Across four decades, multiple train journeys and dozens of minor characters, Bhattacharya sutures together a riveting portrait of a young republic cleaved by caste and religion. The dialogue often sparkles, and the world of the bureaucracy offers many moments of absurdity. "What can I say?" he says. "India is a funny place, life is funny." ■

—Bhavya Dore

FICTION RECCOS

THE BOOKS THAT SHOULD BE ON YOUR READING LIST

with cinematic clarity and luxurious detail.

In Ruthvika Rao's debut, *The Fertile Earth*, caste politics is played out intersectionally with a generational conflict between the women of a family in rural Andhra Pradesh, even as the Naxalite movement becomes a character of its own. It's that rare book that makes you feel you're reading a land and a people rather than just a set of characters.

I will read Rahul Bhattacharya's shopping list if he doesn't write anything else, but fortunately, 2025 wasn't one of those years. In *Railsong*, his heroine Charu takes a train—not once but many times. A history and a geography of the country seeps out of the crazily readable novel directly into the part of the brain where memorable novels live. Indeed, this is the book we could well remember this year for.

Shanta Gokhale, the irrepressible writer and translator, brings to us from the Marathi the utterly unpredictable *The Woman Who Wore a Hat*, by Kamal Desai, where a woman who has lost her memory breaks into a gathering of men in search of resources to make an animated film. What follows is an enquiry into what it means for a woman to be free.

We should need no reminder that 'there are more things in heaven and earth...than are dreamt of in your philosophy'. And yet Amitav Ghosh's *Ghost-eye* does just that, melding a 'case of the reincarnation type' being studied by a psychiatrist in the 1960s with climate investigations in the present day. With a trademark narrative that moves seamlessly between different periods of time, the novel brings out the uncanny truths that stories can reveal. ■